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DISTANCES
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Café de la Luna
research series
Evgeniy Tyurkin
September 18, 2026
CITIES
PEOPLE
STORIES
IN ONE
SYSTEM
SYSTEMS
OBSERVER
Blueprint.
We Made It!
St. Petersburg, Toronto, and the People Between
Sometimes, to find yourself, you need to go very far.
Toronto
FUJIFILM
X100S
Toronto
LED
YYZ
A NEW
CHAPTER
AHEAD
Better
Questions
A Brighter
Life
"Eternal Cycle" Publishing
Krasnoyarsk, 1979
0–10 · author's edition
NOT FOR SALE

Café de la Luna Research Series

Blueprint. We Made It!

St. Petersburg, Toronto, and the People Between

Evgeniy Tyurkin

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NOT FOR SALE

St. Petersburg, Toronto, and the people in between

This story is reconstructed from memory. Some dialogue is reproduced by meaning rather than as a verbatim quotation. Whenever I describe another person's motives, I try to distinguish what happened from my own interpretation of why it happened.

The soul of the project

When I joined Blueprint Systems in St. Petersburg, the company was already standing at the edge of a major technological transition. A decision had been made to move away from the old Java client toward a .NET stack, and at roughly the same time a new team was being assembled in Toronto.

The St. Petersburg office was small, around ten people, mostly Java developers and QA. But headcount explains very little. That small group carried an enormous part of the product's memory. Not only knowledge of the code and architecture, but also the reasons, compromises,

odd corners, old decisions, and all the invisible connections between them.

At the time I did not yet call this an *ecosystem*. Later, one person taught me to look at systems exactly that way.

His name was Israel Ben-Ishai.

He came to St. Petersburg several times with Mike Reidl. We talked at length about how I saw the Blueprint architecture. He spoke with Sasha Utkin, with other developers, with QA. And I think he understood something important very quickly: St. Petersburg did not merely contain knowledge that could be

extracted, documented, and handed to a new team.

It contained the soul of the project.

I would return to that lesson many times later in my career. The architecture of a system does not end with code. If you move one level higher, the system includes people, trust, decision history, culture, customers, management, geography, and even the informal relationships between people who have a beer after work and keep talking about the product long after the meeting agenda has ended.

Israel looked at systems that way.

I cannot state as fact that the move to .NET was intended as a way to close the St. Petersburg office. But at the time I suspected that this possibility was part of the picture: build a new team in Toronto, transfer the knowledge, and eventually make the old office replaceable. At minimum, the organizational trajectory made that possible.

Israel pushed back. He convinced management that simply closing St. Petersburg would not work. What would be lost was not merely a knowledge base. The core would be lost.

As a result, part of the team was given the opportunity to relocate to Canada at the company's expense.

The new product

When I joined Blueprint to modernize the system, my first architectural proposal was simple: cut the face off the thick client.

The old desktop client was a large Java application. Instead of rewriting everything from scratch, I proposed moving the UI into the rapidly developing HTML5 world. WebKit could even be wrapped in an installer, giving us something close to

magic for updates: launch the client, load the latest release, no traditional application deployment.

The idea was rejected.

The main concern was Citibank, our largest customer, and its very old browser environment. Microsoft consultants recommended Silverlight. Their argument was reassuring: a plugin would behave consistently across browsers, and Citibank would not need to change its environment.

I disagreed. Silverlight had arrived as a competitor to Flash and Flex, and the trajectory of Flash was already visible. My

argument was roughly: look at where the web is going. Within a few years HTML5 will push this model out. And rewriting the entire product from zero is strange in itself.

At that moment Microsoft sounded more convincing than I did.

The director who believed the product could be rewritten quickly promised management a first version in about a year. The first genuinely working but still very rough version appeared closer to two years later. There were small bugs everywhere, performance problems, and constant pressure to force reality back into the original

schedule. The director was later let go.

Then one of the assumptions behind the Silverlight plan collapsed as well. The old browser environment at Citibank turned out not to support what the project had been relying on. I no longer remember the exact minimum IE version, so I do not want to invent it.

Later Microsoft itself shifted toward HTML5 and JavaScript, and introduced TypeScript as a way to bring a more familiar structured programming model into the browser.

The irony was nearly perfect.

My last major architectural decision at Blueprint was the move from Silverlight to HTML/TypeScript.

By then we already had a working editor prototype, the decision had been approved, tasks had been written, and developers had started the work.

After several years, the system arrived where I had proposed starting.

The people

The technical side of Blueprint mattered, but without the people this story makes no sense.

Tony Higgins was, to me, the brain of Blueprint on the

management side. He looked far ahead, at what the product should become years later. We talked a lot. Tony would show me the future, and I would lay that future over the actual system and tell him whether the architecture agreed.

John Stetic saw the future differently. If Tony set the direction, John turned it into a tangible product vision. What exactly should the user see? How should the product evolve? Which capabilities should appear, and how should they fit together? Sometimes the three of us talked together: Tony, John, and me.

Mike Reidl became a friend. When he visited our office, Masha and I took him to an Irish pub. Later, in one of those wonderfully human moments, he asked me whether I would mind if he and Vera started dating.

Vera Rumyantseva tested my diagram editor. We used to go outside for smoke breaks together. She was the kind of QA engineer who did more than find bugs. She helped a developer see his own system through someone else's eyes.

Adam White managed the testers. Young, funny, perfectly capable of putting his feet on a table during a meeting while

discussing something seriously, then making a joke a minute later. The QA team loved him. Later Adam would invite me to ViB. We are still on good terms.

Sasha Utkin was a programmer then. Today he is an architect at Autodesk. We worked together a lot, and in practice I taught him quite a bit. I knew that Sasha usually needed only a direction. After that he would start digging like a mole and eventually arrive at the right answer himself.

Marko Vucic reported to me almost immediately after we moved to Toronto. By then the base editor was already built, and the rest of the editors were

being created on top of it. We sat next to each other, and I explained the architecture of the whole application: database, API, server side, editors, and the connections between them. Years later Marko told me I had seemed frightening back then. Serious, focused, meticulous: “What did you understand? No, not quite. Think again. There.”

We became close friends. Our sense of humor is very similar. Marko has since moved back to Serbia with his wife and child.

Andrew Datars was the Chief Architect. His role in this story becomes especially important later.

Vlad Tyuterev joined the early Toronto team with strong Silverlight and .NET experience. His background is a good example of how deliberately the new team was being built around the new technology choice.

And then there was Daniel Shevchenko.

He took the photograph that, many years later, became my LinkedIn portrait.

Fridays

Blueprint had a wonderful Friday tradition that predated Dan Shimmerman. Around three in the afternoon, work effectively stopped. Beer, drinks, and snacks came out. People stayed in the office, talked, laughed, discussed work and everything else.

Then Mike, Vera, Adam, Tony, and I would often move to the bar across the street on Toronto Street. Marko and Sasha joined later. John was often part of the broader Friday circle as well.

This was not “corporate culture” from an HR slide deck. It was the actual human fabric of the team.

And that is why I eventually asked Dan Shimmerman a question that probably cost me my job.

The question

Under the new management, some things that had previously been normal started disappearing. In particular, a year passed without the usual bonuses or salary adjustments.

For me personally, the money was not critical. I was already paid well.

What worried me was that I could see an unusually good team beginning to come apart.

At an all-hands meeting I publicly asked Dan what was happening with bonuses and salary reviews.

I remember his look clearly. Cold. And a smile that, to me, felt predatory. He said something roughly along the lines of, “I’ll remember you.”

I do not claim that as an exact quotation. The feeling of the moment, however, stayed with me.

From my perspective I had asked about the health of the system. From his perspective it may have sounded like a public challenge to authority. That part is my interpretation.

Roughly a month later the issue was indeed “resolved.” I received a raise and a substantial bonus for *exceptional work*.

I used that bonus to buy a Fujifilm X100S.

The camera had only recently been released. Before it there had been the X100. I liked the X100S immediately because it reminded me of the old FED cameras from my childhood.

I brought it to the next Friday gathering to photograph friends and, admittedly, to show off my new toy.

Tony looked at it and said:

“I have the same one.”

I did not believe him.

“That can’t be. It was literally just released.”

Tony took out his phone and showed me a photograph of his own X100S.

As it turned out, this was a very Blueprint kind of moment: “That can’t be” often meant only “show me the evidence.”

Fighting stupidity

Around the same period there was another conversation with Dan.

He wanted the Word documents generated by the product to be

displayed directly inside Blueprint instead of being downloaded and opened in Word.

The meeting included Dan, me, and someone from Product. Not Andrew, and not Tony.

I had already built a prototype. Technically, we could show the document through an iframe layered over Silverlight. It worked, but it was glitchy and architecturally fragile. The iframe was not part of Silverlight, and the boundary between the two promised a long list of strange problems.

My recommendation was simple: the best solution was to do nothing.

The user downloads the document and opens it in Word, the application designed for exactly that purpose. A very Unix answer: let each tool do its own job.

If an embedded viewer was truly mandatory, I could investigate Silverlight components. But the Word document structure is complex, and finding a component that would render everything without errors seemed unlikely. I was willing to research it.

Dan insisted on the iframe.

I explained the risks again.

He said this was not merely desirable. It was necessary.

Then he asked for an estimate.

I said:

“Six months minimum to reach a finished result.”

“Six months?!”

“Yes. Conservatively.”

That was the end of the conversation.

The photograph

About two weeks after the bonus came the Friday gathering when Daniel told me he was leaving for Google.

I was genuinely happy for him.

“With your brain, that is exactly where you belong.”

We were speaking quietly. I told him what I had already started to see: under the new management Blueprint was sinking, and people would begin leaving. I did not want to leave myself. The product felt almost like my child. But I did not want to watch the team disappear either.

Someone relayed the substance of that conversation to Dan.

I do not know who, and I do not want to speculate.

That same evening Daniel picked up my new Fuji X100S and took my portrait.

About two weeks earlier I had received a bonus for *exceptional work*.

About two weeks later I was fired.

The entire interval from bonus to dismissal was about a month, and the photograph sits almost exactly in the middle.

Years later that photograph became my LinkedIn portrait. The banner behind it is another photograph made with the same X100S, this time by me: a snail slowly crossing the ground, with

a long shadow stretching beside it.

Between those two photographs now sit two words:

Systems Observer.

The title did not exist then.

The way of looking already did.

The day I was fired

I was sick that day.

I still came into the office because there was an important meeting about the future development of the product.

During the meeting I was called away.

Everything had already been prepared: Dan, a lawyer, documents, a severance package. I was told the sentence I still remember:

“It came to my attention that you have problems with loyalty.”

By then, for Dan, loyalty seemed to have become a conclusion rather than a question.

The irony, from my side, was almost the opposite.

I argued because I was too attached to the product and the people.

Loyalty to the product and the team had been read as disloyalty to the manager.

My computer was taken almost immediately.

I went outside and sat on the office steps, smoking one cigarette after another.

Then Andrew Datars called.

He said something roughly like:

“Relax. It’s fine. Better than fine. I already have one foot in Oracle. You won’t disappear.”

And suddenly it became clear that a large part of that same core team was already looking outward.

But that came later.

First there had been the move.

Israel

The dismissal was still years away when the decision was made to relocate part of the St. Petersburg team to Toronto.

Israel did more than push the relocation itself. He did everything he could to make the transition as painless as possible.

The company paid for the legal and immigration work. It paid for the first month in a hotel. When I realized in Toronto that I was not going to find proper housing within that month, the company paid for another two weeks.

Most importantly, Israel met us at the airport himself.

He did not delegate that to HR.

He came in person.

Only later did I understand the lesson.

If you are moving part of a living system, you cannot think only about code and contracts. You have to reduce friction for the people carrying that system inside them.

Architecture sometimes includes an airport, a hotel, a family, and a person waiting at the arrivals exit.

Two weeks before departure

Two weeks before the move, a critical situation developed inside the family.

I do not want to disclose the details here. What matters for this story is that by the time we left, the emotional pressure was enormous, and the move no longer felt like an ordinary family plan.

I knew one thing: Eva and I were going.

Everything else had to be resolved separately.

Eva was eight years old.

For her, the whole experience must have looked like a film

with missing subtitles: packing, suitcases, airport, airplane, adults preoccupied with things she could not fully understand, and the world changing around her.

St. Petersburg, Helsinki, cognac

The route was St. Petersburg, Helsinki, Toronto.

The flight to Helsinki was about two hours. The connection was also around two hours.

In duty free I bought a good bottle of cognac. One liter, forty percent.

On the plane Masha and Eva were seated separately from me.

Next to me was an elderly, short East Asian man. I do not want to claim now whether he was Chinese or Japanese. What remains in memory is an image, not a passport.

There were no cups.

I took a few drinks directly from the bottle.

After two weeks of tension, warmth moved through my body and the muscles finally started to release.

I looked at my neighbor.

Offering an elderly stranger a bottle I had already drunk from felt impolite.

So I poured cognac into the bottle cap.

He looked surprised, but accepted the invitation and drank.

I drank again.

Then I poured him a second cap.

By then I was enthusiastically explaining to him, in English that he apparently did not understand, that we Siberians and the peoples of the East had a great deal in common and should develop cultural cooperation.

The content of the speech did not get through.

The attitude apparently did.

About an hour later the bottle was empty.

And the previous two weeks finally caught up with my body.

I shut down.

The Helsinki I do not remember

My own memory is very simple.

I fell asleep on the plane to Helsinki.

I woke up on a plane descending into Toronto.

Helsinki barely exists in my memory.

Masha later reconstructed that part for me.

After landing I was in no condition to function normally. She guided me by the arm, while I moved the luggage on autopilot. Eva, eight years old, had no idea why her father had suddenly become strange.

At the gate for the Toronto flight, the staff looked at my condition and began thinking seriously about passenger safety.

Then another problem appeared.

Of the three of us, only I spoke English comfortably.

Masha could manage simple phrases. Eva did not speak English at all.

Masha assumed nobody in Helsinki would speak Russian, so she tried to argue with the gate staff using gestures and rudimentary English.

Somehow I assessed the situation.

I collected whatever brain cells were still available and said slowly:

“Let’s make this simpler. Explain the situation calmly. In Russian.”

They found a Russian-speaking staff member.

The moment Masha heard her native language, everything became easier. She calmly explained that we were moving

to Toronto as a family, that people were waiting for us there, that I had to be in the office in two days, that the previous weeks had been extremely stressful, and that I had simply relaxed too much.

They let us board.

After that, there are no frames in my memory again.

The next one is the plane descending over Toronto.

I woke up completely sober.

No hangover.

February 29

It was February 29, 2012.

Of course it was.

At Canadian immigration we had three different statuses. I had a closed work permit, Masha had an open one, and eight-year-old Eva had a student permit.

The officer asked the purpose of our arrival.

I showed him the documents and the employment contract.

He decided to verify the employer.

I had the office number as a backup. Israel knew the exact arrival time and had promised to meet us.

It was around nine in the morning.

A Wednesday.

The officer called the office.

Nobody answered.

I suggested trying again.

He waited about twenty minutes and called again.

Nobody answered.

Wednesday. Around 9:30 a.m.

Not Monday. Not Friday. An ordinary middle-of-the-week morning.

I said:

“There is a backup option. The most senior person in the

company is meeting us personally. Here is his phone number."

The officer called Israel.

No answer.

I explained with complete confidence:

"He is definitely here. I am one hundred percent sure. Senior Vice President of Engineering. Please try again."

The officer tried again.

Israel did not answer.

After the miracle of getting through Helsinki, only one step remained between us and the new life, and now the company we had crossed an ocean to join

could not confirm its own existence through any available interface.

The officer looked at us carefully.

Husband.

Wife.

Eight-year-old child.

Suitcases.

Three matching documents.

Employment contract.

He looked through the paperwork one more time.

“All right. Go ahead.”

And we did.

What the hell?

Israel was indeed waiting for us on the other side.

He hugged us like family and said he had already been standing there for about an hour.

My first question after the hugs was:

“What the hell?!”

Israel calmly explained:

“I saw that somebody called me twice from an unknown number. I don’t answer unknown numbers.”

That was the entire mystery.

We had spent almost an hour proving to an immigration officer that a man existed while that same man stood only a few dozen meters away and deliberately ignored an unfamiliar number.

The person was fully present.

The interface to his presence was unavailable.

We made it

Israel put us in his car and drove us from the airport to the hotel.

At first there were open spaces outside the window. Then the city gradually began assembling itself: roads, buildings, traffic. We were getting closer.

And suddenly the classic Toronto skyline appeared outside the car.

Morning.

Sunlight.

Cold.

After everything that had happened, it looked like a miracle.

We had arrived.

At the hotel Israel helped with the luggage, came upstairs with us to the second floor, and handled something with the staff along the way.

He stayed in the room for five minutes.

Looked around.

Cozy.

Everything was fine.

Then he said goodbye. He hugged each of us again, one by one, and shook my hand.

“See you tomorrow. At the office.”

There was a lot of important work ahead.

The door closed.

The three of us were left in a hotel room, in an unfamiliar city, in a new country.

Outside was a bright, freezing morning.

We made it.

What came next was another story.

Three years in a new country. Permanent resident status. Dismissal. Citizenship. A citizenship exam that became its own comedy.

But all of that comes later.

For now, one thing is enough:

We made it.